products of extraordinary situations, but they do illustrate what is an undeniable reality. And it is that our daily life is increasingly influenced by what happens elsewhere, be they problems or solutions.

So, the next time you are watching a foreign visit, hearing a discussion on an important relationship or reading a debate about interests abroad, take it very seriously. Remember that this may have a direct bearing on your well-being. Foreign policy matters not just in distress situations. It could literally determine your security, your job, the quality of your life and, as we discovered recently, even your health. It shapes what you hold dear: pride, values, reputation and image. For all these reasons and more, it is important that you take a greater interest in the world and understand what that could mean for your prospects.

Let us explore what foreign policy could mean for you personally. If you are an Indian student, it may be the ease of getting a visa, the ability to travel during times of Covid and perhaps employment after studies. If you are a businessperson, it could help you get access to foreign markets, receive information on regulations and practices, and, where circumstances demand, obtain assistance to solve problems. For professionals and workers, this may be visible in ensuring fair employment contracts, a stronger sense of protection and welfare measures in times of difficulties. For a stranded tourist, a sympathetic embassy provides much-needed succour and support and, in more threatening circumstances, even evacuation.

But you do not have to be abroad to need foreign policy; it matters at home just as much. When it comes to security, external or internal, diplomacy could be a preventive measure, a mitigator or a problem solver. It can help raise awareness of a shared threat just as it can find partners against common dangers. So, if you are a soldier guarding our frontiers or a policeman grappling with terrorism, a good foreign policy makes your life a little easier. And then there is the economy, with its search for investment, technology and best practices, which can be enabled only by foreign policy.

In each of these sectors, foreign relationships can accelerate India’s progress. Cumulatively, what they do is expand employment and improve your quality of life. Whether it is the price of cooking oil that is imported or a smartphone produced collaboratively, a larger policy decision has just made some difference to your purse. Indeed, if there were any doubts at all